



UNITED NATIONS CHILDREN'S FUND (UNICEF)

Background Paper

Topic: Child Mortality, Famine, and the Deterioration of Children's Quality of Life in Gaza

Chair: EMILIANO SALAZAR

Moderator: VALENTINA PEREZ

I. The United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF): History and Powers

The United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) is a specialized agency of the United Nations established in 1946 by the UN General Assembly.

Historical Background

UNICEF was originally created to provide emergency relief to children affected by World War II. In 1953, it became a permanent part of the UN system, expanding its mandate to address long-term child welfare and development worldwide.

Today, UNICEF operates in more than 190 countries and territories. It plays a central role in humanitarian crises, particularly in conflict zones, natural disasters, and areas affected by poverty and instability.

Over time, UNICEF has played a crucial role in:

- Promoting child survival and development
- Expanding global immunization programs
- Supporting universal primary education
- Addressing child malnutrition
- Protecting children in armed conflict

Powers and Functions

UNICEF has the authority to:

- Deliver humanitarian aid in emergencies
- Conduct research and publish global child welfare reports
- Advocate for the protection of children's rights
- Support governments in implementing child-focused policies
- Coordinate with other UN agencies and NGOs

Although UNICEF does not create legally binding resolutions, its recommendations strongly influence international humanitarian and development strategies.

II. Introduction to the Topic

The Gaza Strip is currently facing a severe humanitarian crisis that has drastically affected children. Ongoing armed conflict, destruction of infrastructure, limited humanitarian access, and economic collapse have led to rising child mortality, famine conditions, and a severe deterioration of children's quality of life.

Children represent nearly half of Gaza's population, making them the most vulnerable group in the crisis.

III. Historical and Humanitarian Background

Gaza has experienced prolonged political instability and repeated escalations of violence over the years. However, recent conflicts have significantly worsened humanitarian conditions.

Key developments include:

- Destruction of hospitals and healthcare facilities
- Shortages of food, clean water, electricity, and medical supplies
- Massive displacement of families
- Closure or destruction of schools
- Increasing rates of acute malnutrition among children

The healthcare system has become overwhelmed, limiting access to treatment for injuries, infections, and chronic illnesses. In addition, the lack of clean water and sanitation increases the spread of preventable diseases.

Psychological trauma has also become widespread among children exposed to violence, displacement, and loss of family members.

IV. Socio-Humanitarian Impacts

The crisis in Gaza directly affects children in multiple ways:

1. Rising Child Mortality

Preventable deaths caused by malnutrition, dehydration, untreated injuries, and lack of medical supplies.

2. Famine and Food Insecurity

Severe shortages of food have increased rates of acute malnutrition, particularly among infants and young children.

3. Healthcare Collapse

Damaged hospitals and shortages of fuel and medicine prevent life-saving care.

4. Water and Sanitation Crisis

Contaminated water sources increase the spread of waterborne diseases.

5. Education Disruption

School closures interrupt children's learning and long-term development.

6. Psychological and Emotional Trauma

Exposure to violence and displacement has resulted in long-term mental health challenges.

These impacts disproportionately affect children from low-income and displaced families.

V. International Framework

Relevant international frameworks include:

- The Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC)
- International Humanitarian Law
- The Geneva Conventions
- The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), especially:
 - SDG 2: Zero Hunger
 - SDG 3: Good Health and Well-being
 - SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation
 - SDG 16: Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions

Despite these frameworks, humanitarian access remains inconsistent, and funding gaps continue to hinder emergency response efforts.

VI. Current Situation (2026 Context)

As of 2026:

- Child mortality rates have significantly increased.
- Food insecurity has reached critical levels.
- Healthcare systems remain severely damaged.
- Large portions of the population remain displaced.
- Humanitarian agencies call for sustained ceasefires and expanded aid corridors.

International discussions continue regarding humanitarian access, reconstruction funding, and protection of civilians, particularly children.

VII. Key Questions for Debate

Delegates should consider:

- How can UNICEF ensure safe and sustained humanitarian access in Gaza?
- What immediate measures can reduce child mortality and famine conditions?
- How can long-term reconstruction prioritize children's rights and well-being?
- What role should international funding and partnerships play?
- How can compliance with international humanitarian law be strengthened?

VIII. Conclusion

The crisis in Gaza represents not only a humanitarian emergency but a profound threat to an entire generation of children.

UNICEF plays a vital role in:

- Delivering life-saving humanitarian assistance
- Advocating for children's rights
- Coordinating international support
- Supporting long-term recovery and development

Delegates must develop comprehensive solutions that address both immediate survival needs and long-term protection of children's rights to ensure stability, dignity, and hope for the future.

Document drafted and edited by [María José Fortanet Cárdenas](#).